



Clientelism and Democratic Paradox in Latin America

How does electoral competition coexist with practices that fundamentally undermine the autonomy and equality of citizens? Despite widespread adoption of secret ballots, competitive elections, and modern campaign technologies, vote buying and clientelism remain deeply integral to political life across the region.

These practices represent a distinctive form of "particularistic exchange" in which politicians strategically provide material benefits—food bags, cash payments, government jobs, or preferential access to public services—in explicit return for political support. The key analytical challenge facing scholars is understanding why rational voters continue to comply with these arrangements and why political parties persist in deploying these methods despite their apparent inefficiency, high costs, and technical illegality under democratic electoral law.

Perverse Accountability and the Logic of Machine Politics

01

The Central Puzzle

Stokes begins with an apparent contradiction: if the vote is genuinely secret, how can a political machine credibly ensure that a voter who receives material benefits will actually vote for the patron? The traditional economic model of "vote buying" assumes that rational citizens can renege—accepting the gift but voting freely according to their true preferences—yet empirical observation shows that machines continue to operate successfully across Latin America.

02

Perverse Accountability

This contradiction lies at the core of what Stokes theorizes as "perverse accountability." In standard democratic accountability, citizens actively monitor politicians and reward or punish them through elections based on performance. In perverse accountability, this direction is fundamentally reversed: politicians monitor and strategically punish citizens for their electoral behavior, inverting the democratic logic.

03

Social Monitoring Mechanisms

Stokes argues that machines overcome the technical protection of secret ballots through sophisticated social monitoring. Local activists (called "punteros" or brokers in Argentina) personally know voters and can reliably infer voting behavior. In contexts where ballots are distributed by parties rather than neutral state authorities, and where voters live in tightly knit communities, anonymity becomes fragile and ultimately unsustainable.

The Formal Model and Targeting Strategy

Repeated Game Framework

Stokes formalizes the machine–voter relationship as a repeated Prisoner's Dilemma where trust and fear sustain cooperation over time:

- The machine offers tangible benefits conditional on political support
- The voter can either reciprocate (vote for the party) or defect (accept benefits but vote freely)
- Because interactions repeat over electoral cycles, and the machine can infer voting behavior with reasonable probability, strategic cooperation emerges
- Voters who consistently support the machine continue receiving aid; defectors risk exclusion or retaliation

Thus, monitoring capacity, ongoing personal contact, and selective resource targeting become the key ingredients sustaining durable clientelist relationships.

Strategic Targeting

Stokes challenges earlier theoretical models that claimed machines primarily target core supporters. Instead, empirical evidence shows they strategically prioritize swing or uncertain voters—individuals poor enough to genuinely value small material benefits, but not ideologically committed to the party.

"She distributes scarce resources ('ten little bags of food') to 'the people who complain the most'—those whose future loyalty remains in doubt."

Machines thus allocate resources not to the faithful base, but to the persuadable middle—maximizing electoral returns on clientelist investments.

Democratic Consequences

Perverse accountability systematically corrodes democracy by undermining voter autonomy, reducing incentives for policy performance (since votes can be bought rather than earned through governance), and reinforcing social hierarchies between brokers and the poor. The electoral process transforms from expressing programmatic preferences into maintaining patron–client chains of reciprocal favors.

Measuring Clientelism in Colombia

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From Theory to Measurement

While Stokes modeled clientelism conceptually, Fergusson et al. tackle the complex empirical challenge of rigorously quantifying it. Using the Encuesta Longitudinal Colombiana (ELCA)—a comprehensive panel of 10,000 households—they design an innovative list experiment to estimate how many voters actually engage in vote trading, while statistically correcting for the social desirability bias that typically plagues survey responses on sensitive political topics.

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The List Experiment Method

Respondents are randomly assigned to control or treatment groups. The treatment group receives a list including the sensitive item: "the benefits, gifts, or jobs the candidate offered you in exchange for your vote." The control group receives an identical list without that item. The statistical difference in average items checked between groups reveals the estimated proportion of voters involved in clientelist exchanges.



Do not tell me which, only how many.”¹⁵ Then they are handed a card with the following options:

1. The information about the candidate on the radio or television.
2. What you read about his or her government plan.
3. **The benefits, gifts, or jobs the candidate offered you in exchange for your vote.**
4. The conversations you had with your friends about the candidate.
5. The candidate's party.

Prevalence and Normalization

Using pregression analysis and extreme bounds robustness checks, the authors identify variables consistently associated with higher likelihood of selling votes:

- Poverty and economic vulnerability emerge as the strongest predictors, dramatically increasing participation in clientelist exchanges
- No consistent gender or religious effects are observed across models
- **Municipal-level factors** such as weak institutional capacity and endemic local corruption significantly reinforce clientelist practices

"Clientelism and a weak state reinforce each other as normal features of the political landscape."



The absence of social stigma and prevalence across diverse social sectors suggest a political equilibrium: citizens not only tolerate but actively expect clientelistic practices because they pragmatically fill critical gaps left by a weak or profoundly unequal state. Clientelism offers immediate, tangible returns in exchange for political loyalty, effectively substituting for the absence of credible public goods provision.

Comparative Framework: From Control to Normalization

Dimension	Argentina (Stokes 2005)	Colombia (Fergusson et al. 2018)
Analytical Focus	Mechanism of control: how machines enforce loyalty despite secret ballots	Measurement of prevalence: how widespread and socially normalized clientelism has become
Core Concept	Perverse accountability: politicians monitor and punish citizens, reversing democratic logic	Normalization of exchange: citizens openly admit vote selling without shame or stigma
Primary Mechanism	Social monitoring and repeated strategic interactions within dense community networks	Economic vulnerability combined with systematically weak state capacity and service delivery
Implication for Democracy	Fundamental erosion of citizen autonomy; complete reversal of democratic accountability	Deep acceptance of clientelism as normal, expected part of political culture and practice
Theoretical Contribution	Sophisticated dynamic model of iterative machine–voter strategic interaction	Rigorous empirical test using list experiments with extensive robustness analysis

Both cases powerfully reveal that citizen disaffection in Latin America does not simply arise from political apathy or ideological fatigue, but from structural distortions embedded in representation itself. When votes are systematically exchanged for immediate material favors rather than programmatic promises, citizens rationally perceive politics as fundamentally transactional, reinforcing cycles of cynicism, dependency, and democratic disillusionment.

Disaffection and Democratic Quality

Erosion of Democratic Accountability

Clientelism fundamentally transforms accountability from vertical (citizens over rulers) to reverse accountability (rulers over citizens). This inversion systematically undermines responsiveness, as politicians cater to short-term client needs rather than broad policy demands; representation, as voters cannot credibly punish poor governance; and equality, as the poor are systematically targeted and controlled through material dependence.

Socioeconomic Roots of Disaffection

Both papers reinforce that poverty and structural inequality are absolutely central to this pattern. In contexts characterized by scarce public goods and chronically unreliable institutions, clientelism provides the only predictable channel of access to state resources. The poor thus become simultaneously the primary targets and reluctant participants in sustaining the system—a dynamic that fundamentally blurs the line between coercion and consent.

Psychological Dimensions

The Colombian evidence of complete lack of shame adds a crucial psychological layer to understanding citizen disaffection. When clientelism becomes thoroughly normalized in political culture, cynicism systematically replaces moral outrage. Citizens no longer perceive vote selling as corruption requiring condemnation, but as pragmatic participation in an inevitable system—explaining why many Latin Americans simultaneously express abstract support for democracy while approving concrete non-democratic shortcuts.

Connecting to Broader Frameworks

These findings directly reaffirm several core theoretical propositions in comparative politics: institutional weakness enables clientelism; social networks and brokers substitute for formal representation; iterated interactions sustain cooperation through fear, reciprocity, or necessity. The outcome is persistently low-quality democracy, characterized not by overt authoritarian repression but by subtle transactional domination.